

Learning and Knowledge Management

Color Brand Guide

Overview

This guide combines color psychology evidence from multiple sources to optimize readability, learner engagement, and emotional impact in Learning environments.

Colors serve different psychological and cognitive purposes in marketing versus learning, and these differences are rooted in how they engage distinct areas of the brain. In marketing, colors are primarily used to trigger emotional responses and influence decision-making. Bright, saturated hues like red and orange activate the limbic system, which governs emotions and urgency, stimulating the amygdala to create excitement or a sense of scarcity. Blue and green in marketing often appeal to trust and calm, engaging the prefrontal cortex to reinforce rational decision-making and brand reliability. Essentially, marketing colors aim to capture attention quickly and drive action by leveraging emotional and reward pathways.

In learning environments, color usage focuses on cognitive processing and memory retention rather than impulse. Cooler tones such as blue and green are favored because they activate the prefrontal cortex and parietal lobes, areas associated with focus, reasoning, and spatial awareness. These colors help reduce cognitive load and stress, creating an optimal environment for sustained attention and comprehension. Warm colors like yellow are used sparingly to highlight key concepts, stimulating the hippocampus, which plays a role in memory formation, without overwhelming the learner. Unlike marketing, where contrast and vibrancy are tools for persuasion, learning design prioritizes calm, clarity, and accessibility to support deep processing.

The neurological impact reflects these intentions: marketing colors often engage the brain's reward system and emotional centers to prompt quick decisions, while learning colors aim to activate regions responsible for executive function and long-term memory. This distinction underscores why marketing palettes lean toward bold, high-arousal hues to drive conversions, whereas educational palettes favor balanced, low-arousal tones to foster concentration and retention. Both strategies are effective within their contexts because they align color psychology with the desired cognitive outcome—action versus understanding.

Learning and Knowledge Management

Color Brand Guide

	Marketing	Learning
Purpose	To trigger emotional responses that drive action (e.g. purchasing a product)	To aid comprehension and retention for recall
Color Usage	• Bright, saturated hues (e.g. red, orange) • Contrast and vibrancy • Evokes urgency, excitement, trust	• Cool, calming tones (e.g., blue, green) • Use balance and highlights • Promote focus, clarity, and memory
Affects	Amygdala Processes emotions and adds emotional significance to memories. Flight or Fight response.	Hippocampus Central to learning and crucial in forming long-term memories and learning. Memory hub for facts, events, locations, helps build mental maps and remember sequence of events. Links events with context.

Core Background Colors

Primary Light Background (#F5F7FA)

Soft cool gray-blue. Low-stimulation canvas for long-form reading; reduces visual fatigue.

Alternate Background (#FFFFFF)

Use for print-friendly and high-contrast screens.

Deep Blue Canvas (#0F4C81)

Calming trustworthy backdrop. Creates a sense of stability; supports focus. This is also great for assessment headers and dashboards.

Learning and Knowledge Management

Color Brand Guide

Typography Colors (Web Content Accessibility Guidelines AA+)

■ Primary Body Text (#1F2937)

Dark neutral on light backgrounds.

■ Headings on Light Background (#0B1F33)

Deep navy for strong hierarchy without harsh black.

■ Inverse Text (#FFFFFF)

Use on dark backgrounds and buttons.

Interaction & Highlights

■ Primary Action (Blue) (#1976D2) or ■ Product Primary Blue (#0069B1)

Preferred for calls to action buttons; For trust and focus. Signals calm and reliability.

■ Positive/ Success (Green) (#2E7D32) or ■ Product Flavor Green (#509E2F)

Indicates harmony & growth; For progress, completed steps, and confirmations.

■ Highlight (Warm Yellow) (#FFB300)

Use sparingly for tips, key notes, callouts, and emphasis.

■ Critical/ Warning (Red) (#D32F2F)

For errors, urgent notices, and alerts only. Avoid large areas.

Extended Palette

■ Info/Links (Teal) (#00ACC1)

Informational banners and hyperlinks; clear without competing with calls to action.

■ Advanced Topics (Purple) (#8E24AA) or ■ Product Flavor Purple (#BB29BB)

Use for advanced topics, certification badges and expert-level cues.

■ Cards/Dividers (Light Gray) (#E5E7EB)

Structure content with low visual load, such as borders, lines, and card backgrounds.

■ Secondary Text (Gray) (#9CA3AF)

Captions and helper text; verify contrast.

Learning and Knowledge Management

Color Brand Guide

Design Rules (quick checks)

- **Readability first:** maintain accessibility contrast
- **Limit accents:** Use no more than 1 primary and 2 secondary accent colors per screen.
- **Highlight sparingly:** Yellow for emphasis; red only for warnings/errors
- **Calm canvases:** Prefer light neutrals or deep blue for content-heavy pages.
- **Visual hierarchy:** background neutral, headings deep navy, call to actions blue.
- **Consistency of interaction and highlights:** Reserve the blue for action, green for success, yellow for highlight, red for critical).
- **Branding & trust:** keep palette cohesive; avoid overusing saturated warm hues.
- **Accessibility:** don't rely on color alone; pair with icons and labels; check red/green combos.

Sources

[The eLearning Color Guide: Evoking The RIGHT Emotion](#) (eLearning Industry).

[Color Psychology in eLearning: how colors influence learning](#) (DyneDevice).

[The Ultimate Guide to Color-Coding in eLearning](#) (eLearning Industry).

[Be color wise – best practices for using color psychology in e-learning](#) (Training Journal.com)

[Best Color Combinations for Educational Websites](#) (Verpex).

[What Learning Professionals Should Know About Color](#) (The eLearning Coach).

[Exploring the Most Effective Colors for Online Learning](#) (EdisonOS)